A PRIMER FOR PLAYERS

Erwood: The Weight of the Sky

Four cities ride the sky above the greatest jungle in Naever. Today, for the first time in your life, one of them has sent for you.

The campaign

This is a short D&D 5e campaign, about eight sessions, running from level 3 to level 8 by milestones. It's a dark jungle adventure with treasure, ruins, monsters and real danger.

Your character applied for the Uplift Scholarship, and has just won. The story begins with something going badly wrong. You will survive it.

Expect violence and gore, people taken from their lives, cruelty to captives, and children in danger. Tell your GM before the first session if you want anything kept off the table.

Erwood

It is the end of the Dry in 997 YK, a year after the Treaty of Thronehold ended the Last War. Erwood broke away from old Nostale during that war and simply never answered to anyone again. It has no king and has never taken a census. People say it's the safest place in Naever to carry a dragonmark, because nobody here keeps a list.

The year has two seasons, the Dry and the Wet. The Wet begins in a few weeks, and the rivers will drown the roads.

COIN	WORTH	FOR SCALE
Copper crown (cp)	10 to the sovereign	A meal at Ninefold is a crown or two
Silver sovereign (sp)	10 to the wynar	A day's work pays a few of these
Gold wynar (gp)	10 to the dragon	A good sword, or a month's careful living
Platinum dragon (pp)	10 wynars	Few people below have ever held one

The sky

Lift-stone is mined in the Hollowcrown and flies every airship in Naever. A worked stone binds an air elemental, and the craft is well understood. Anywhere else, it can raise a ship. Only over Erwood, where the Seal on magic is thin, can it raise a city.

CITY	WHAT IT IS
Cassarine	The first city: the banks, the vaults, the guns and the Tonnage's great hall
Halcyne	The city of gardens, and home of the Collegium
Tetherhold	The city of foundries and airship sheds, chained to the ground
The Skerries	A flock of drifting islands, with estates, temples and a prison rock

A fifth city, Serenfall, fell in 957 on the southern tip of the Hollowcrown. Its wreck is the richest salvage in the Green.

Getting up there

A home in the sky is called a **berth**, and no one can buy one. You live above only if a Sky Family invites you. A Family's written invitation or pass is called a **weight letter**, and clerks check every letter at the Weighgates on the Chain, the great iron chain from Anchor Sorrel up to Tetherhold.

Visitors can buy a **day pass** from Corvane for 500 wynars a head. It lasts until dusk. Everything else is illegal: forged letters, smugglers' skiffs, or climbing the Chain itself. Being expelled from the sky is called being *weighed out*, and it means going over the edge in the Drop.

The Sky Families

Six Families have held Erwood for more than three centuries. They govern through the Tonnage, and nearly everyone below works for one of them, or for someone who does.

FAMILY	BELOW	ABOVE
Corvane	The Chain, the Anchors, the airships and the guns	The Tonnage's chair and the banks
Halloran	The Hollowcrown mines and mine forts	Cassarine's vaults
Ysmay	Collegium stations and survey posts	The Collegium at Halcyne
Brask	River mills, foundries, the Shardworks	Tetherhold's yards
Tasque	Salvage, debts and the Gleaners	A quiet house on the Skerries
Dael	The plantations, timber and beasts of the Spill	Estates on the Skerries

The Green

The jungle is rich, and it kills people. All of Erwood lies in a vast crater left when a star fell from the sky. The **Hollowcrown**, a great crescent of mountains, walls it in on the north, east and south. Streams run down from

the mountains into the clear lake at its center, the **Ysse**. On the open western side, the river pours out through the floodlands of the **Spill** into the Western Sea. That ocean is full of monsters and Erwood has no usable port, so almost nobody arrives by sea. The grey land under the cities' drift is the **Fallow**, and the ruins and sinkholes are the **Deep Green**.

Havens

HAVEN	WHAT IT IS
Rootfast	A town in the roots of one colossal tree, run by a council. The healer Alara Venn heals for a promise.
Ninefold	Nine lashed rafts on the Spill, where anything can be bought
The Quiet Hollow	A dead valley with a Host hermitage, where no magic works

Who lives here

- **The Ywen** are river people older than the cities. They don't cast spells. They ask, and the green answers. Three cuts on a root mark a safe trail.
- **Shifter clans** are the finest guides in the Green.
- **Lizardfolk** trade and raft on the Spill, and hold Ninefold together.
- **The stuck** are miners, soldiers, contract hands and their children, who came down and stayed. They call themselves that with a grin.
- **The Sloughborn** were born under the cities' drift and changed by it, with bark skin, extra eyes and spell-scars. They raid Family convoys under a leader called the Undertow.
- **Gleaners** work for Tasque, and travel in threes with a net, a sack and a cage-raft.

The old advice about the grey hunters of the Fallow is to find a tree or the river, then wait.

Magic and gods

No mortal spell can pass the ninth circle. The Sovereign Host teaches that this is Aureon's Seal. In Erwood the Seal is thin, so magic misbehaves. Most of the jungle is **thin ground**.

Magic in the Green is dangerous enough that a great deal simply isn't attempted. Armies march with spears and no war-mages, and airships stay high above the canopy. Rootfast's calm is worth more than gold.

At the table: magic can act wildly on thin ground, for good or ill. Cantrips always work. Magewrights carry calmstones as a precaution.

The Sovereign Host

GOD	STANDS FOR	CLERIC DOMAINS	WHO PRAYS TO THEM HERE
Aureon	Law, knowledge and magic	Knowledge, Arcana	Scholars and the Collegium
Arawai	Fertility, plant life, abundance and rain	Life, Nature	Farmers, plantation hands and the Ywen
Balinor	Beasts, the hunt and the wild	Life, Nature	Hunters, trappers and shifter clans
Boldrei	Community, home and marriage	Life	The havens, where a place at the fire is sworn in her name
Dol Arrah	Honour, sacrifice and sunlight	Light, War	Fort garrisons, who swear their oaths by her
Dol Dorn	Strength, courage and the soldier's craft	War	Guards, Chainhands and anyone who climbs the links
Kol Korran	Trade, wealth and travel	Trickery	Merchants, the Families and Ninefold's raft-folk
Olladra	Luck, feasts and good fortune	Life, Trickery	Gamblers and the stuck, who pray for a way up
Onatar	Artifice, the forge and fire	Forge, Light	Smiths, millhands and the Shardworks

Naever's other gods, Odin, Hoar, Isvarr, Moradin and Surtur, have their followers too.

The Uplift Scholarship

The Uplift is the most famous prize in Erwood, and the one invitation an ordinary person can win. It is awarded by the Collegium.

- **To apply,** you sit an interview with a recruiter and hold a brass reading-stone that measures your aptitude. Hundreds apply at every fort and raft-market.
- **At the Naming,** fifteen names are read aloud at Fort Halloran's gate, every sixth day. Winners are called Scholars from that moment.
- **The prize** is a year of study and service, then a berth for you and one person you choose.
- **The journey** is three days down the cut road to Station Nine, then by teleportation circle to Halcyne. Scholars who finish their year are awarded the Scholar's Knot.

At every Naming the recruiter also reads out the names of past Scholars now berthed above. In the cities, a board lists them.

Your character

Build a level 3 character using the standard array, point buy or rolled stats. Feats and Tasha's optional rules are allowed. Any published race and class is welcome, including shifters, changelings, kalashtar, warforged and dragonmarks. Any published background works, and so do Erwood's own: Weighed Out, Haven-born, Chainhand and Rootway Refugee.

How did you end up below?

D8	YOU ARE
1	A guard let go when your Halloran garrison was reduced
2	A contract hand whose work ended far from home
3	Weighed out of Cassarine, and you survived the Drop
4	Shipwrecked when your airship or skiff came down
5	A survey hand left behind on a Collegium expedition
6	Born below, and you've only seen the cities from underneath
7	Marked, and smuggled in down the Rootway
8	Applying for someone else's sake

Questions you may have

QUESTION	ANSWER
Who rules the jungle?	No government does. Each Family guards its own works, and the havens run themselves.
Do Eberron's books apply?	Use their races, gods and dragonmarks. Places and history are Naever's own.
What languages are spoken?	Common, Ywen, Old Nostalean and the standard 5e languages.
How do people treat unusual races?	People below don't much care. The cities are snobbish about anyone from below.
Can I play a Ywen or Sloughborn?	Yes, as a reskinned race. Talk to your GM. A Sloughborn needs a good reason to be accepted for the Scholarship.
Can I be from a Sky Family?	Only a minor or disgraced relative.

QUESTION	ANSWER
Can I come from another nation?	Yes, by the Rootway, a contract or a wreck.
Are there guns?	Only cannon. No hand firearms.
Can someone rich apply?	Yes, though the prize favours those who need it most. Money can't buy a berth.
Can another player be my "and yours"?	No. Every PC has won a place of their own.
Do our characters know each other?	They can, or you can meet at the Naming.
Is it lethal?	Session 1 can't kill you. After that, yes.
What if my character dies?	You'll bring in a new character with a connection to the story.
Can I fly up to a city?	You can try once you have the magic. Corvane's guns fire on anything flying without leave.
Can we be evil?	Morally grey is welcome. Don't betray the party.
How strict are rests and supplies?	Standard rests. Supplies matter only on long journeys.